

This was, in spirit, the forefather of what Apple CarPlay is today. iPod Out was rolled out to select BMW and MINI cars, with their infotainment systems carrying a ‘PlugIn’ mode to enable showing the iPhone’s contents on the car’s display. This, however, never really picked up in terms of popularity. Users were still alien to requiring extensive mobile connectivity while driving, app support was limited, in-car displays were comparatively slipshod, and the iPhone itself was yet to truly reach out to larger markets.

At Apple’s 2013 Worldwide Developer Conference, SVP of Internet Service and Software Eddy Cue took the wraps off what was called ‘iOS in the car’. This was basically a more refined version of iPod Out and all the features that it had offered, put together in a more cohesive manner. Following the demonstration of technology, the Geneva Motor Show in March 2014 saw Apple CarPlay being launched in its present avatar, and the Ferrari FF became the very first car to include Apple CarPlay in its in-car technology package.

So, what does it really do?

Essentially, Apple CarPlay mirrors the iPhone’s screen on to a car’s main display. It includes a familiar iOS interface but with a few changes such as an on-screen home button, large and chunky icons to access the different native apps, compatibility with select third party apps, and integration of Siri’s voice assistance.

In its present form, Apple CarPlay uses a car’s integrated display as a secondary extension of the iPhone itself. It is one of the many third party infotainment interfaces that aim to provide a familiar format of features for users. With Apple CarPlay, a user gets access to call lists, contacts, messages, music and Siri as standard features across all regions. Navigation via Apple Maps and third party application support varies according to region, and is dependant on the applications installed in the phone.

With Apple CarPlay, most of the operations are voice controlled and the primary mode of interaction, alongside touch input, is Siri. With CarPlay enabled, you do not get a text view of your messages or contacts. Instead, you have Siri reading out the messages and making calls for you. CarPlay scrolls only the last 10 message senders, and not showing text messages is a deliberate measure to avoid distraction for drivers.

Apple CarPlay does not get a keyboard interface in India. However, in international markets where Maps are available, you may choose to add destinations via a keyboard instead of only relying on voice. Somehow, Apple has not yet